

GERONIMO



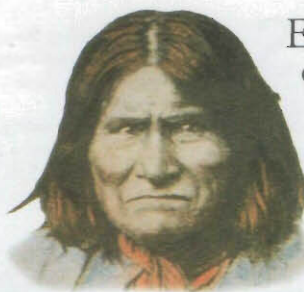
A CENTURY AFTER the native people of North America fought the white settlers to stay on their land, one name is remembered above all others. As a fearless warrior, Geronimo had no equals. In his early 20s, he lost his entire family to Mexican raiders, and he determined to fight to the death to safeguard his Apache way of life. Only in old age, defeated by the superior arms of the US government, did he surrender, ending his days as a wealthy farmer, revered by people across the USA.

Apaches

The Apaches lived among the arid mountains and deserts of southwest USA. Because their land was unsuitable for farming, they earned a living hunting and raiding for food. This brought them into conflict with the many settlers who were moving into the area from Mexico and the eastern USA.



Native American encampment



Early life

Geronimo was born in about 1829 in Arizona, southwest USA. He was a member of the Mimbrenño Apache tribe, and his Apache name was Goyanthlay. Spaniards called him Geronimo.

Massacre

In 1858, a band of Mexican raiders killed Geronimo's mother, wife, and children. Geronimo was filled with a deep hatred of white people, and decided to spend the rest of his life fighting them.



The young warrior

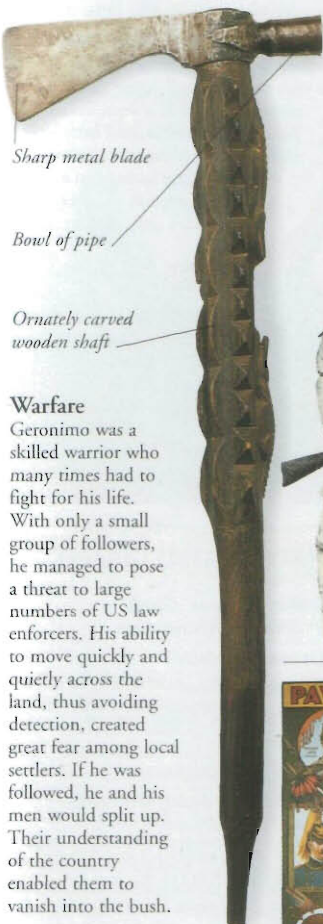
As a young warrior, Geronimo was trained to shoot, track enemies or wild animals across the land, map out a new and unfamiliar terrain, and survive for days away from camp. He also learned the skill of travelling through the countryside over vast distances without being observed. For recreation, he took part in Apache games such as the loop-and-pole game (left), arrow shooting, and wrestling.

Reservations

As European settlers pushed west, Native Americans were forced into special areas called reservations. The Native Americans were, therefore, excluded from their traditional lands and prevented from roaming over vast areas as they had done before. In response, many tribes broke out and raided neighbouring areas.

San Carlos reservation

In 1877 Geronimo and 16 of his warriors were captured by US forces and marched 400 miles to the San Carlos reservation in Arizona. The new reservation was brutal and corrupt, with suppliers making vast fortunes at the expense of the native inhabitants. Many resentful and half-starved Apaches left the reservation to go on raids.



Sharp metal blade

Bowl of pipe

Ornately carved wooden shaft

Warfare

Geronimo was a skilled warrior who many times had to fight for his life. With only a small group of followers, he managed to pose a threat to large numbers of US law enforcers. His ability to move quickly and quietly across the land, thus avoiding detection, created great fear among local settlers. If he was followed, he and his men would split up. Their understanding of the country enabled them to vanish into the bush.

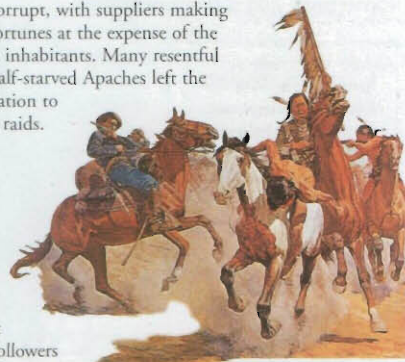
Apache tomahawk pipe



Raiding

US officials tried to reform the San Carlos reservation, but Geronimo and his followers continued their raiding. Overwhelmed by the superior force of the US Army, Geronimo was forced to surrender in 1886.

Geronimo (far right) before his surrender



Fort Sill

After his surrender, Geronimo was sent first to Florida, then Alabama, and finally, in 1894, to Fort Sill, Oklahoma. He sold native American handicrafts, became a farmer, adopted Christianity, and appeared at the 1904 St Louis World's Fair and in President Theodore Roosevelt's inaugural parade in 1905. To the end of his life, he hoped to return to his native southwestern mountains.

GERONIMO

c.1829 Born in Arizona, USA.

early 1850s Raiders kill his family.

late 1850s Accepts Cochise, head of the Chiricahuas, as his leader, and marries a Chiricahua wife.

1876 Retreats into the Sierra Madre mountains and raids both sides of the US-Mexican border.

1877 Confined to the San Carlos reservation, but continues to raid the surrounding lands.

1886 Surrenders; exiled to Florida.

1894 Confined to Fort Sill.

1909 Dies at Fort Sill.

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